

EG MENA Crisis, Oil, Saudi Arabia, Yemen QUICKTAKE: Airport strike raises risk of Houthi actions targeting Saudi energy

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MENA Crisis, Oil, Saudi Arabia, Yemen QuickTake

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Airport strike raises risk of Houthi actions targeting Saudi energy

What happened:

An airstrike hit Sanaa International Airport on 13 July as an Iranian passenger plane carrying a Houthi delegation prepared to land in a direct challenge to operational restrictions put in place by the Saudi-backed government of Yemen. The Houthis blamed Saudi Arabia for the strike and threatened retaliation, warning that the current de-escalation phase has ended.

Our take:

The Houthis are likely to follow through on threats against Saudi targets. The Yemeni group has spent weeks warning Riyadh that it will resume attacks unless Saudi Arabia provides additional financial relief to Houthi-controlled areas. Reports that the kingdom helped cover public-sector salaries in March—but has not repeated the support since—reinforce Houthi incentives to use escalation as leverage. The airport strike gives the Houthis a fresh pretext to pressure Saudi leaders for concessions, including reopening Sanaa airport on Houthi terms.

Iran's encouragement makes actions against Saudi energy likely. Although Tehran does not directly control Houthi decision-making, it retains meaningful influence and has indicated that additional regional fronts (including Yemen and the Red Sea) could activate if confrontation with the US expands. A Houthi attack, or the announcement of measures against Red Sea shipping, that raises the economic cost for Saudi Arabia would also help Iran project escalation without it taking direct responsibility, especially amid heightened pressure around regional shipping routes and ongoing escalation with the US over the Strait of Hormuz.

Any attacks on Saudi oil facilities or Red Sea shipping would probably be limited in scope. The Houthis could choose from a reciprocal attack on Saudi airports, strikes on the East-West Pipeline and/or the Yanbu export terminal, or action against oil tankers carrying Saudi crude in the Red Sea. Still, the Houthis remain financially and militarily exposed and must factor in Saudi missile defenses as well as the risk of a broader counteroffensive from the roughly 400,000 Saudi- and government-aligned Yemeni

forces. The most likely outcome is a limited, high-impact signal—such as a one-off attack on an energy-linked target—designed to extract payments and political concessions rather than trigger a prolonged war.

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